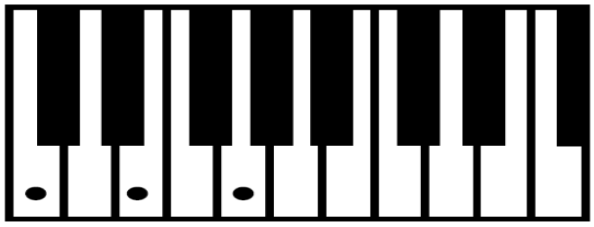
To construct for example, a C major chord on a keyboard/piano, see below:



1) Start on the root, which is C
2) Go up 4 half-steps to E
3) Go up 3 more half-steps to G

Keep in mind that a chord has a root. In simple terms, **the root is the first note**, or lowest note of a chord. For instance, a C chord starts with a C note, and a G chord starts with a G note and so on. It is also **essential to remember the root is perhaps the most important note on the chord**[20]. See diagram below.

CHORD SYMBOL	ROOT	FLAVOUR
C	C	Major
Cm	C	Minor
C7	C	Seventh
C Major 7	C	Major Seventh
C minor 7	C	Minor seventh
C aug	C	Augmented
C dim	C	Diminished

In music theory, **the distance between any two notes is described as an interval. Intervals depict precisely the differences in pitch between two notes**.

For example, the interval of the middle C and the G above it is referred to as a Perfect 5th. Grasping an understanding of intervals is crucial to the basics of chord construction.

Further, another school of thought refers to intervals as half steps, followed by a whole step. We need to remember that the two closest keys together equal a half step. Two half steps put together equal one whole step.

For example, if C to C# to D is the next half step, then C up to D is a whole step. This explanation leads to the different chord structures that make a Major or a minor chord. Simply put, this is how we construct chords.

We build chords by describing the distance (in half steps) between notes.

CONSTRUCTION OF MAJOR CHORDS

Major chords simply mean happy chords. These chords are very important in composing, songwriting, and arranging because everything revolves around them. They convey a myriad of moods and different types of emotions can be expressed with them. They are often said to sound positive, upbeat, or happy. To an extent, you can even express sadness with them.

We need to reiterate that in building a chord we start from the root and count the steps until you have all the notes in the chord figured out.

We can then begin to see how the famous C major chord is constructed. We can do so by the following:

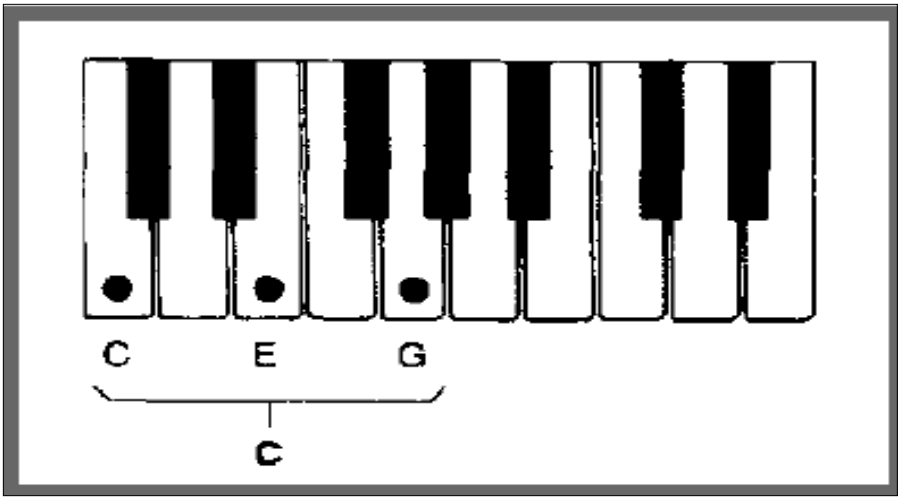
- Play a C note on the keyboard,
- Go up four half steps and play that note,
- Then go up an additional 3 half steps and play that note,
- You will be playing C, E, and G, the notes of the C Major chord.

RULE

1. The number of notes in the chord C in this case are three, and,
2. The distances between these notes in this case

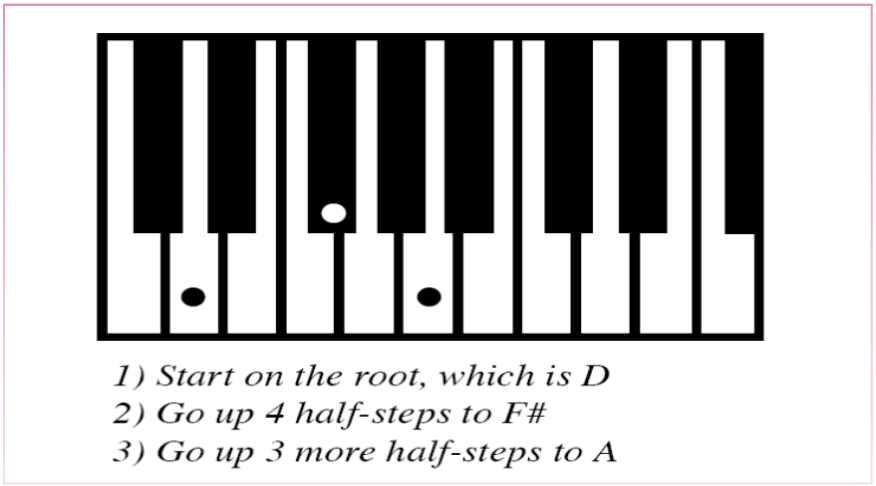
    - The root
    - Up four half steps
    - Then three half steps

Once you can retain these variables in your memory, and of course by heart, you can construct any chord that is found in music.



Another example is the D Major chord. Once we have kept the rule in our minds, let us construct this chord.

1. Start on D (the root)
2. Go up four half steps to F#
3. Then go up three more half steps to A.



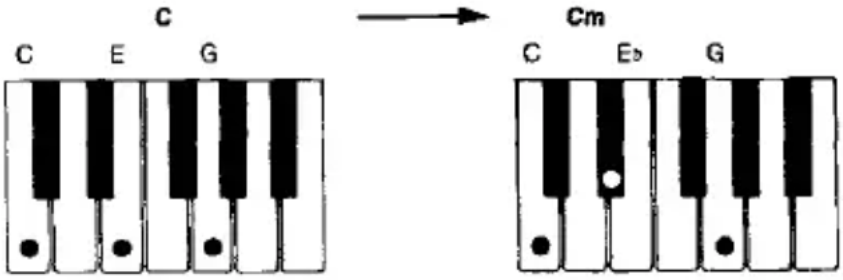
A further example is the F Major chord. The same rule applies.

1. Start on F (the root)
2. Go up four half steps to A
3. Go up three half steps to C.
4. You have F, A, C, or the F Major chord.

CONSTRUCTION OF MINOR CHORDS

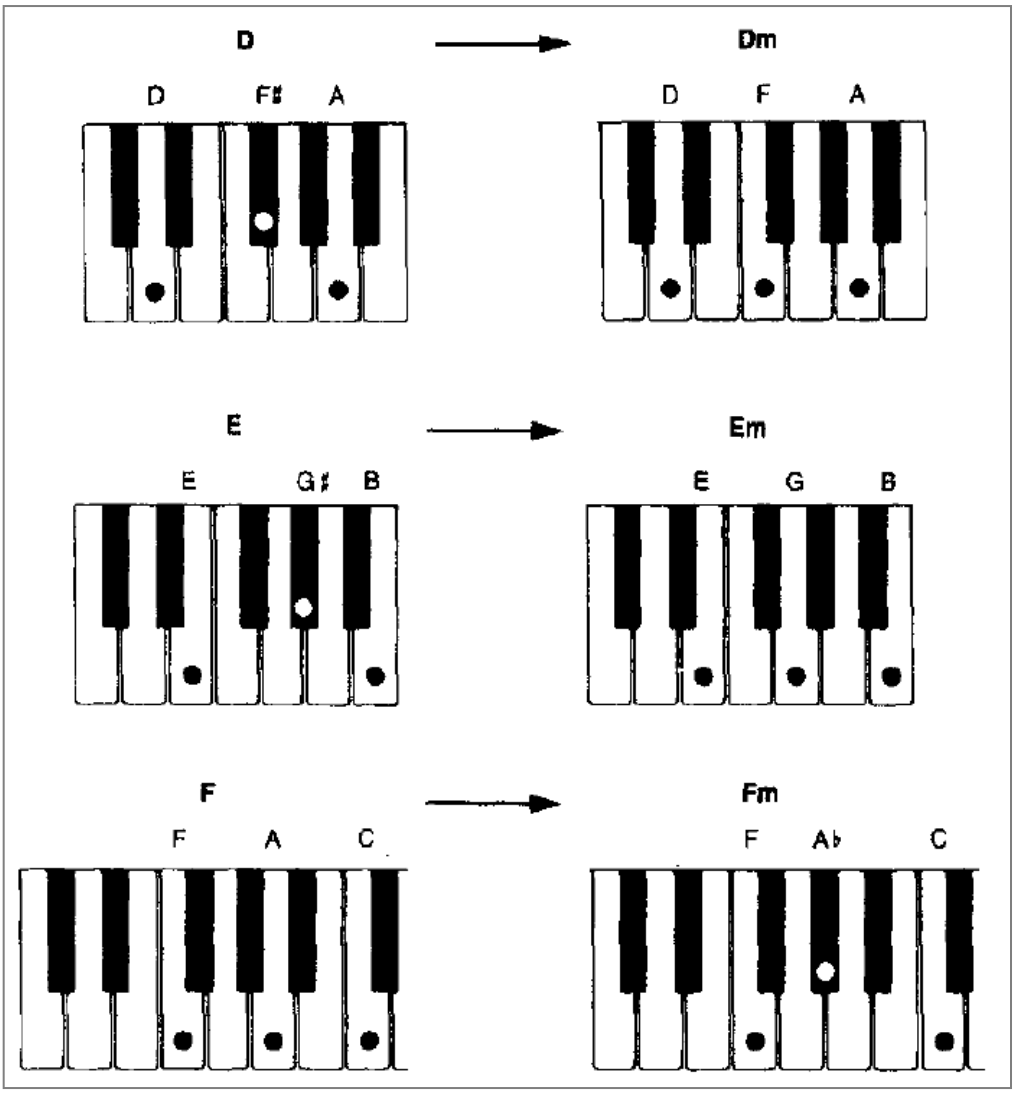
Minor chords are musically **constructed to sound sad, unhappy or melancholic**.[21] Most popular songs contain progressions of minor and major chords to create an aesthetic and emotionally stimulating mood. Certain genres of music, such as Indian music does not have chord sequences; rather Indian songs are mono-chordal, without chord or key changes.

To construct a minor chord is to change from a major chord to a minor chord. We can simply lower the middle note (the third) by a half step (flatting it, in other words). For example, C.E.G are the notes for the C major triad. Thus, by flattening the middle note E, we get C, Eb, G, constituting the C minor triad, with a 'Cm' symbol. In popular songs, you will find it above the melodies in vocal line and lead sheets.



Play these famous used chords and familiarize yourselves with their sound and appearance. Play the version first, then the minors.

See the examples in the next image from the transition to major and minor chords.



DIFFERENT CATEGORIES OF CHORDS

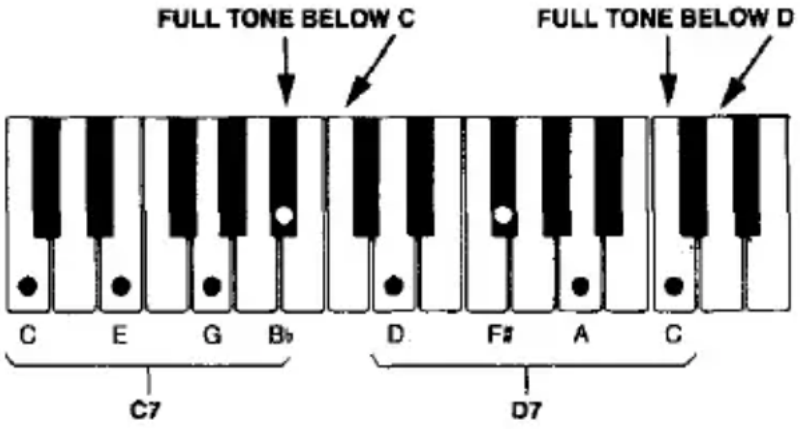
MAJOR, minor, seventh, major seventh, minor seventh, augmented, and diminished.

CHORD SYMBOL	ROOT	FLAVOUR
C	C	Major
Cm	C	Minor
C7	C	Seventh
C Major 7	C	Major Seventh
C minor 7	C	Minor seventh
C aug	C	Augmented
C dim	C	Diminished

Evidently, we have seen the major and minor chords. Now we can have the opportunity to look at the mechanics of other chords.

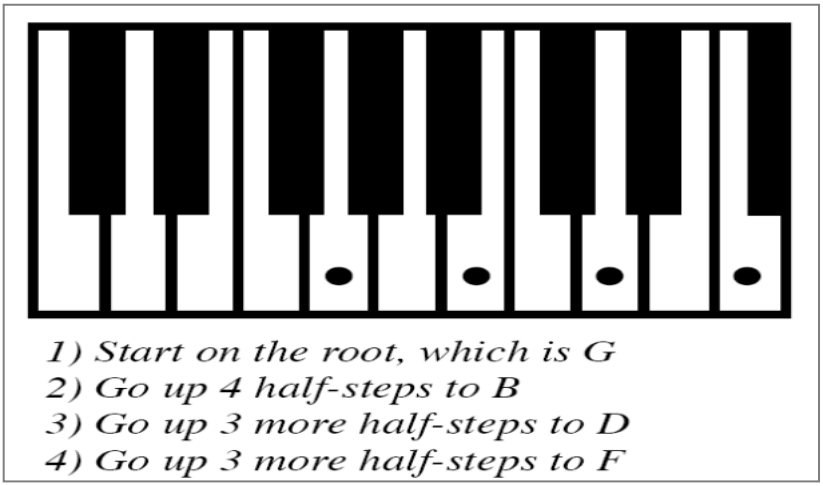
7TH CHORDS OR 4-NOTE CHORDS

7th chords are sometimes referred to as dominant chords. Dominant is Latin for leading; thus **the dominant chord leads to another chord**. For instance, a C7 chord will lead to an F chord or G7 to C. This style is so splendid that the professionals have called it the **Perfect Cadence**. They have been used in popular music for the last hundred years.[22]



7th chords are formed by adding another note to a triad. A number that indicates its scale degree often identifies this note.

See example of a G7 chord below:



The diagram below is the scale of C Major:

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
C	D	E	F	G	A	B

The triad of C Major chord is made by bringing together the notes of C.E.G (1,3,5). The dominant seventh chord is formed by adding the note one tone (one full step) below the root.

When you listen to Blues music, one can hear that dominant 7th chords are used a lot of times. Popular music also relies on dominant 7th chords. It has this hard-bluesy sound.

MAJOR SEVENTH CHORDS

To specify a major seventh chord, the abbreviation 'MAJ' must be used to make it different from the dominant chords. Thus, a C Major Seventh Chord will look like this:

C MAJ 7

To construct a C Maj 7, you add the seventh note in the scale to the C major triad you are already familiar with.

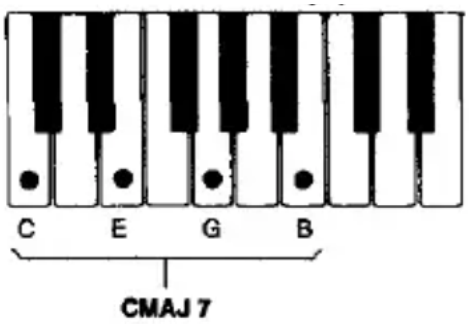


Image Source: How to Play Popular Piano

Looking at the two opposite sonic landscapes, the major seventh has a romantic quality. For this reason, it is splendid in expressing gentle, intimate emotions. We can find such chords in ballads, soul music, and pop. Further, it fits better to slow tempo because at speeds, the nuance of the chord is easily lost.[23]

MINOR SEVENTH CHORDS

We can recollect that minor chords sound sad and melancholic. However, a minor seventh chord has a sad quality but not as sad as the straight minor. It is best to combine with major chords.

Further, a song composed in minor seventh would be less depressing than one written entirely in minor chords. They also combine nicely with major sevenths, a well-known trick in soul music.

Movie score composers rely on a combination of **minor // major** seventh because of its suspense feel. In popular music, they are used as **transitions**, for example, **Cm/Cm/maj 7/Cm7**.

Example

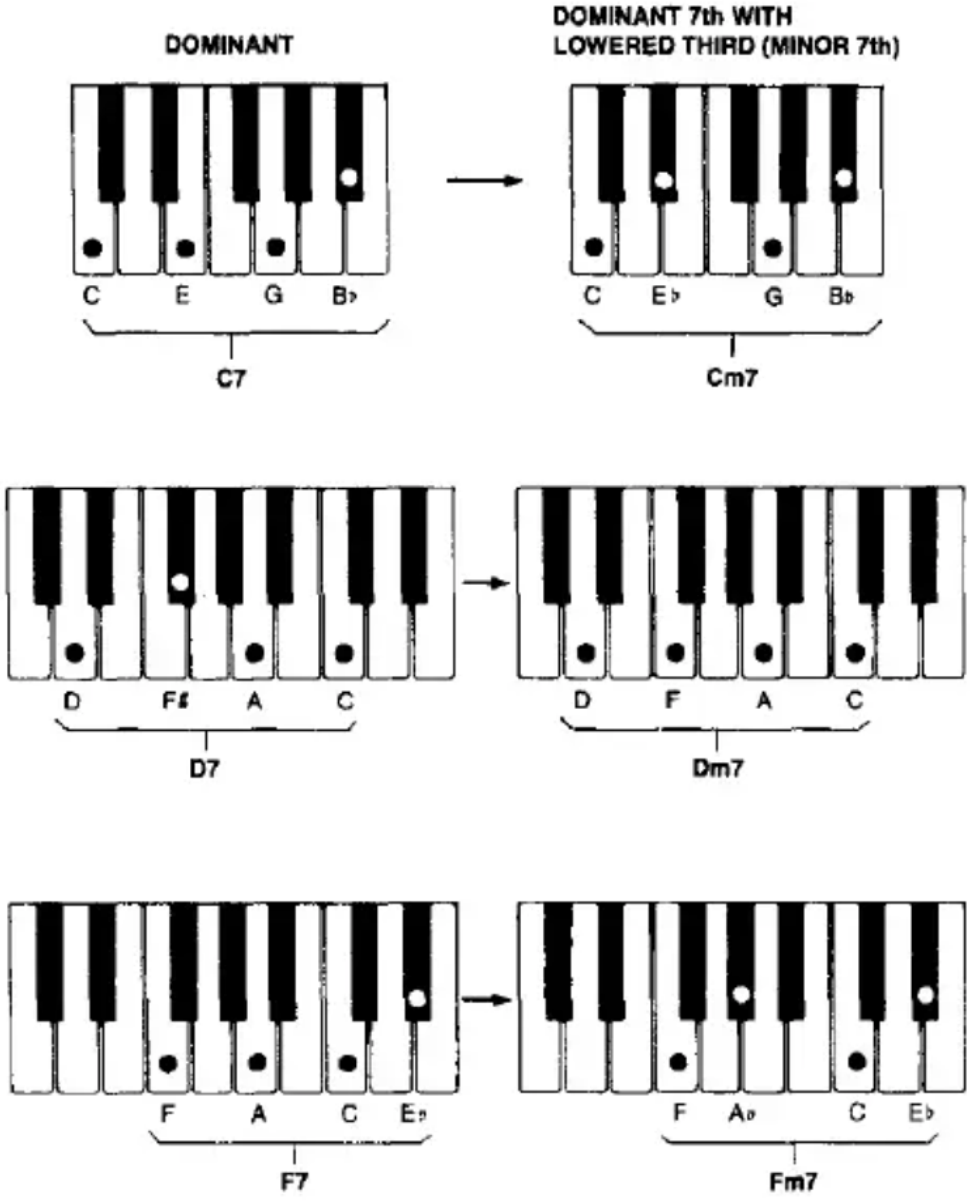


Image Source: How to Play Popular Piano

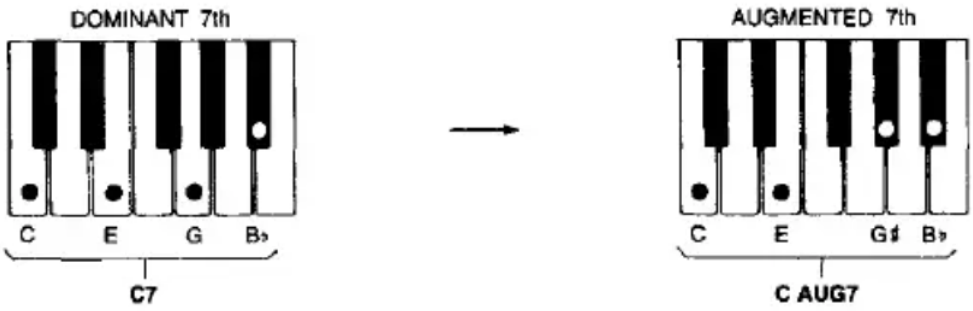
AUGMENTED CHORDS

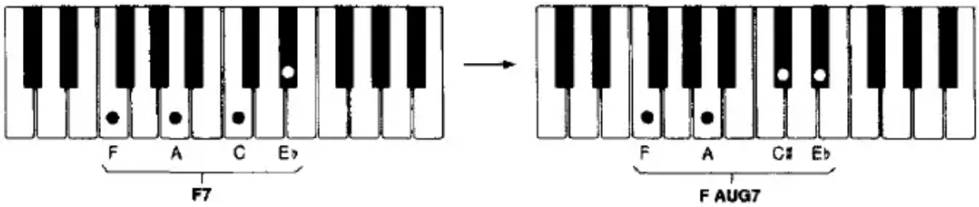
Belonging to the chord dictionary are the augmented and diminished chords. These chords are not so popular because they are rarely used.

The augmented is a major triad where the top note, fifth, is sharpened:

C E G becomes C E G#

The sound is quite tense and never played for more than a beat. It is usually found as a transition chord between a major and a minor chord or a major sixth or major seventh.[24]





F AUG7

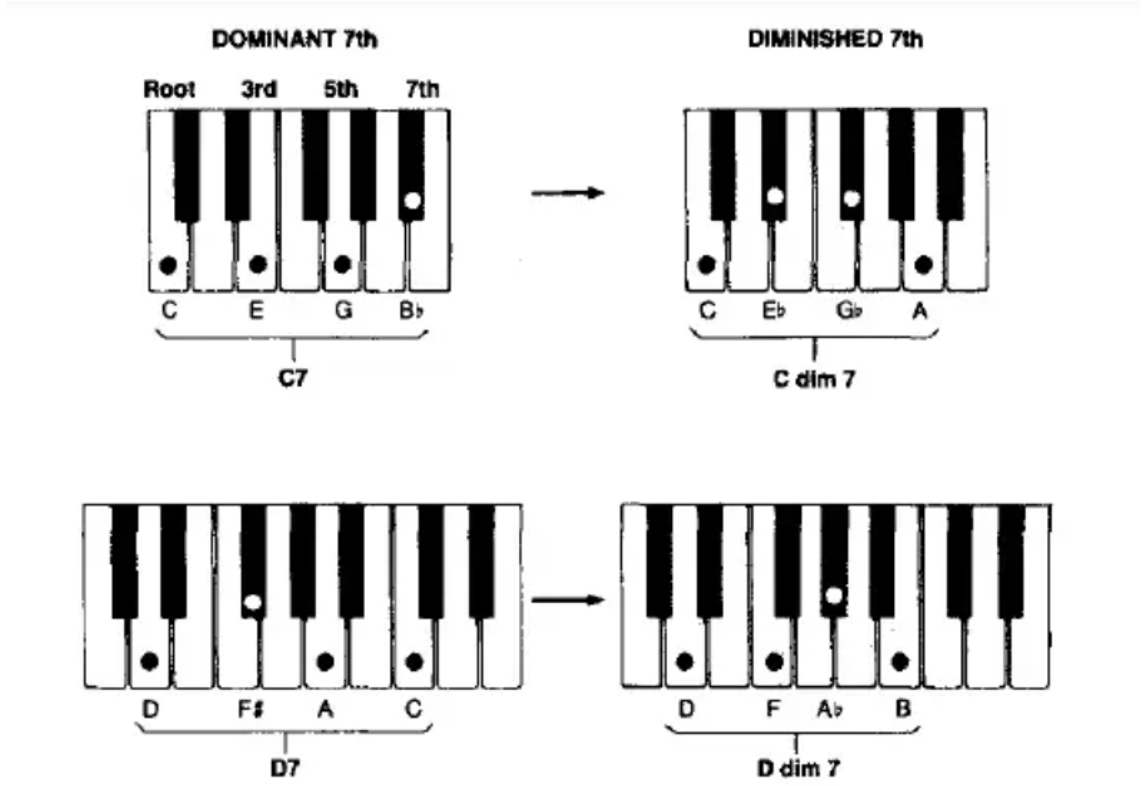
DIMINISHED CHORDS

Diminished chords are formed in the same way as augmented chords. The diminished triad is not used on its own. Instead, another note one-and-a-half tones above is added to create a diminished seventh:

C Eb Gb Bb (B double flat = A in pitch)

The sonic characteristic of a diminished chord is like a dominant seventh chord. It is widely used in jazz and musicians such as Meatloaf and David Bowie have used it several times in their songs to create a state of awe.

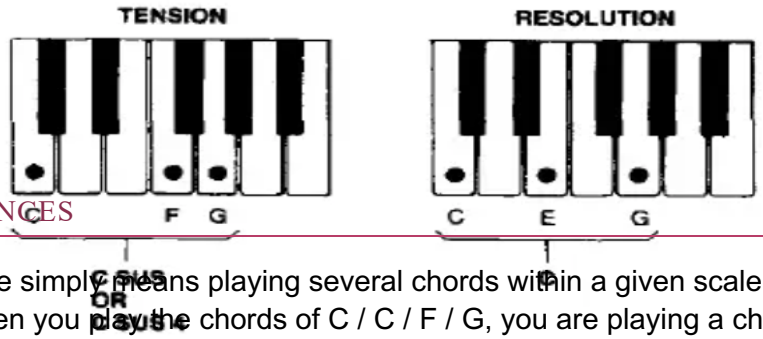
See the construction of the diminished 7th chord below.



OTHER CHORD TYPES

Suspended 4th Chords

Omitting the third from a triad and replacing it with a perfect fourth leads to a suspended fourth'4th 'or' sus 4' chord.



CHORD SEQUENCES

A chord sequence simply means playing several chords within a given scale or tonality. For example, when you play the chords of C / C / F / G, you are playing a chord sequence in the key or tonality or scale of the C major chord.

See examples of chord sequences below.

Chord sequence of ‘Are you lonesome tonight’, in the key or tonality of C

```
C| | | | |A|Dm| |G| | | | | |C| | | |F| |D| |G| |C| |D| |G||C,,F|G{f}|
```

```
C| | | | |A|Dm| |G| | | | | |C| | | |F| |D| |G| |C| |D| |G||C   |{f} |
```

Chord sequence of ‘Candle in the wind’ by Elton John

```
E| |A| |E| |A| |E| |A  | |E| |A        |{f}|
B| |E|A|E| |B| |A| |C#m| |B|A|,G#m,F#m|E  |B{f}|
E| |A| |E| |A| |E| |A  | |E| |A        |{f}|
B| |E|A|E| |B| |A| |C#m| |B|A|,G#m,F#m|E  |B{f}|
E| |A| |E| |A| |E| |A  | |E|A|         |{f}|
B| |E|A|E| |B| |A| |C#m| |B|A|,G#m,F#m|   |C#m |B|A| |E{f}|
```

Chord sequence of ‘Get back’ by the Beatles

```
F| |Bb|F| | |Bb|F| | |Bb|F| | |Bb|F{f}|
F| |Bb|F| | |Bb|F| | |Bb|F| | |Bb|F{f}|
```

Chord sequence of ‘Hotel California’ by the Eagles

```
Bm|F#|A |E |G|D|Em|F#   |Bm|F#|A|E|G|D |Em   |F#{f}|
G |D |F#|Bm|G|D|Em|F#{f}|
Bm|F#|A |E |G|D|Em|F#|Bm|F#|A |E|G|D|Em|F#{f}|
G |D |F#|Bm|G|D|Em|F#{f}|
Bm|F#|A |E |G|D|Em|F#   |Bm|F#|A|E|G|D |Em   |F#{f}|
G |D |F#|Bm|G|D|Em|F#{f}|
```

Chord sequence of ‘Killing me softly’ by Roberta Flack

```
Am|F|G|C|Am|Dm|G |F|C |F|Bb|    |A{f}|
Dm|G|C|F|Dm|G |Am| |Dm|G|C |E{f}|
Am|F|G|C|Am|Dm|G |F|C |F|Bb|    |A{f}|
```

```
Dm|G|C|F|Dm|G |Am| |Dm|G|C |E{f}|
Am|F|G|C|Am|Dm|G |F|C |F|Bb|    |A{f}|
Dm|G|C|F|Dm|G |Am| |Dm|G|C |E{f}|
Am|F|G|C|Am|Dm|G |F|C |F|Bb|    |A   | | |
```

Chord sequence of ‘Mrs Robinson’ by Paul Simon

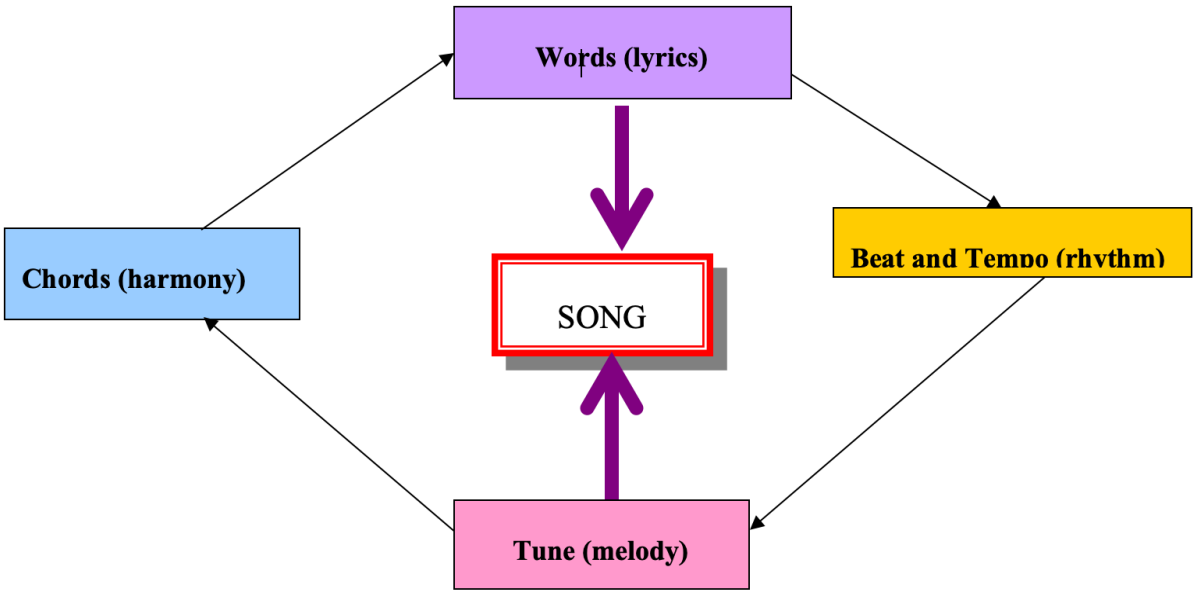
```
G{f}|
C    |Am|C|Am|F|Dm|G |{f}|
C    |Am|C|Am|F|   |Dm|    |A| | |{f}|
A    |   | |   |D|   |   |    |G|C|F|Dm | |A| |G|{f}|
C    |Am|C|Am|F|Dm|G |{f}|
C    |Am|C|Am|F|   |Dm|    |A| | |
```

CHORD PROGRESSION

When you **change** from one chord to another, in any preferable pattern, they are referred to as a chord progression. For instance, when you are playing in the key of C, and you have F and G, physically moving your hand position to the other chords of F and G, you are moving in progression pattern. You must remember in a chord progression when to change to the next chord and or when to go back to the root key of the chord, as simple as that.

A songwriting method

What is a song? See the diagram below.



From the above diagram, we can see that a song comprises four parts. The order does not necessarily impose any known or established method of composing or arranging a song. Most musicians start writing down lyrics in their head, on the piano, with the guitar, raw, and so on. These equate below:

A song = lyrics + melody + harmony + rhythm

Swap these around and you will be surprised to see that you are comfortable starting with a drum rhythm than a lyric and vice versa.